“Good” in Scripture: Hebrew *tov*, Greek *agathos* and *kalos*

Oct 18, 2026 · @Phil

Two different words are in play — Hebrew *tov* in Genesis and Greek *agathos* in Mark — plus a third Greek word, *kalos*, that turns out to be the link between them. They overlap heavily but are not interchangeable, and the difference is useful for teaching.

The words

Genesis 1 — Hebrew טוֹב (*tov*)

“God saw that the light was *good*” (1:4); “it was *very* good” (1:31, *tov me’od*). *Tov* is one of the broadest words in Hebrew. It covers pleasant, beautiful, beneficial, functional, prosperous, and morally good, all in one term. In Genesis 1 the sense is primarily *fit for purpose, as it should be, pleasing to its Maker* — creation working the way God intended. The same word carries the moral sense in “the tree of the knowledge of *good* and evil” (2:9, 17).

Mark 10 — Greek ἀγαθός (*agathos*)

“*Good* teacher… Why do you call me *good*? No one is *good* except God alone” (10:17–18; the same word in the Luke 18 parallel). *Agathos* denotes goodness of nature or character — intrinsic, essential goodness, often with a moral and beneficent edge. This is why Jesus can use it to point at God’s very being: *agathos* is what God *is*, not merely what He does.

The link: the Septuagint

When the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) translated Genesis 1, it did **not** use *agathos*. It used **καλός (*kalos*)**: “God saw the light, that it was *kalon*” (1:4); “*kala lian*” — very good (1:31). *Kalos* means good in the sense of *beautiful, fine, noble, well-made, fitting* — goodness as admirable rightness.

Elsewhere the LXX renders *tov* with *agathos* (Psalm 73:1, “God is *agathos* to Israel”) or even *chrēstos*, “kind” (Psalm 34:8, “taste and see that the Lord is *chrēstos*”). The translators felt the shades inside the one Hebrew word and chose among Greek words to match.

Word	Language	Core sense	Example
tov	Hebrew	good in every sense — fit, pleasing, beneficial, moral	Gen 1:4, 31; 2:9
kalos	Greek	good as beautiful, noble, well-made, fitting	LXX Gen 1; John 10:11 “good shepherd”; Matt 5:16 “good works”
agathos	Greek	good in nature and character — intrinsic, beneficent	Mark 10:18; James 1:17 “every good gift”

Are they equivalent?

Overlapping, not identical. Hebrew *tov* is wider than either Greek word and covers both of their ranges. Greek makes a distinction Hebrew leaves undivided: *kalos* leans toward the goodness you *see* (beauty, fitness, admirable quality); *agathos* toward the goodness something *is* (character, essence, benefit). The LXX translators felt that difference and chose *kalos* for creation — well-made, as it should be — rather than *agathos*.

So “the heavens and earth were *tov*” and “no one is *agathos* but God” are not the same claim wearing two languages. Creation is good as a *made thing* is good — fit, beautiful, right. God is good as the *source* is good — in His very nature.

Why this helps Week 1 of the course

This is the Week 1 thesis sitting inside the vocabulary. Creation's goodness (*tov / kalos*) is *derived* — a well-made thing reflecting its Maker. God's goodness (*agathos*) is *original* — the character everything else borrows from. That is exactly “anything called good is good because it participates in Him.” The two words are not a problem for the claim; they are the claim's grammar.

A way to put it for the class: Genesis 1 says creation is *kalos* — good the way a masterpiece is good. Mark 10 says only God is *agathos* — good the way the Artist is good.

One caution for teaching: do not press the *kalos / agathos* distinction as a rigid rule. The New Testament uses them near-synonymously in places (both describe “good works”), and the LXX is not perfectly consistent. The distinction is a real tendency, not a watertight system — hold it as illumination, not as a proof.